

THE SOURDOUGH STARTER KIT

Your Complete 14-Day Guide to Creating
and Maintaining a Sourdough Starter

*"I killed my first three starters before getting it right.
This guide has everything I wish someone had told me."*

by Elena
Rise & Ferment

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Welcome, Future Baker!

If you're reading this, you've decided to do something amazing: create life from flour and water. Sourdough might seem intimidating, but I promise you this: if you can stir, you can make sourdough.

This guide will walk you through every single day for 14 days. No guessing. No confusion. Just clear, simple steps from someone who's been exactly where you are right now.

By Day 14, you'll have a bubbling, active sourdough starter ready to bake the most incredible bread you've ever tasted. Let's begin.

What You'll Need

Item	Details	Why
Glass jar	Wide-mouth, ~500ml	See-through to watch growth
Kitchen scale	Digital, grams	Precision matters
Whole wheat flour	Organic preferred	More wild yeast
Bread flour	High protein (12%+)	For feeding after Day 7
Rubber band	Any size	Mark rise level
Wooden spoon	Or silicone spatula	For stirring/feeding
Cloth/loose lid	Breathable cover	Airflow, no bugs

Elena's Tip

You probably already have most of these at home. Don't buy expensive "sourdough kits" online. A simple mason jar and a bag of flour is all you truly need to start.

The 14-Day Starter Guide

WEEK 1: Building the Foundation

DAY 1

The Beginning

What to do: Mix 50g whole wheat flour + 50g room temperature water in your jar. Stir until smooth (thick pancake batter consistency). Mark the level with a rubber band. Cover loosely. Place somewhere warm (22-26°C / 72-78°F).

What to look for: Nothing much today. Just a paste in a jar. That's perfect.

Elena's Tip

Use whole wheat flour for the first few days. It contains more wild yeast and bacteria than white flour, giving your starter a head start.

DAY 2

First Signs of Life

What to do: Check your jar. You may see small bubbles. Don't feed today — just observe. If you see bubbles, that's bacteria starting to work. If not, that's also fine.

What to look for: Tiny bubbles on the surface or sides of the jar. Slight increase in volume. A mild, slightly sweet smell.

Elena's Tip

Patience is everything on Day 2. Some starters show activity, some don't. Both are completely normal. Don't compare yours to what you see online.

DAY 3

The Ugly Phase Begins

What to do: Discard half your starter (roughly). Add 50g whole wheat flour + 50g water. Stir well. Mark new level. Cover and wait.

What to look for: Possibly a strong, unpleasant smell. Dark liquid (hooch) on top. This is the "funky phase" and it's 100% NORMAL.

Elena's Tip

Days 3-5 are when most people give up. The bad smell is just bacteria competing for dominance. The good guys will win. Keep feeding.

DAY 4

Keep the Faith

What to do: Discard half, feed 50g flour + 50g water. Same routine. Start using your nose — it tells you everything.

What to look for: The smell may still be strong. You might see some rise and fall. The starter is becoming more active even if it doesn't look like it.

DAY 5

Turning the Corner

What to do: Discard half, feed 50g flour + 50g water. You can start transitioning: use 25g whole wheat + 25g bread flour.

What to look for: The smell should be improving — less funky, more tangy/yeasty. You may notice predictable rise and fall patterns forming.

Elena's Tip

The transition to bread flour gives your starter a different food source. This helps the beneficial yeast population grow stronger.

DAY 6

Getting Stronger

What to do: Discard half, feed with 50g bread flour + 50g water. Consider feeding TWICE daily now if your starter seems very active.

What to look for: More consistent bubbles. Better smell (tangy, yeasty, pleasant). Noticeable rise within 6-10 hours of feeding.

DAY 7

One Week!

What to do: Discard half, feed 50g bread flour + 50g water. Switch to twice daily feeding: every 12 hours.

What to look for: Your starter should be showing reliable activity now. Rising, bubbling, and smelling like tangy yogurt or mild beer.

Elena's Tip

Celebrate! You've kept something alive for a whole week. That's more than most people manage. You're doing amazing.

WEEK 2: Getting Ready to Bake

DAY 8

Building Strength

What to do: Feed twice daily: discard half, add 50g bread flour + 50g water each time. Morning and evening, roughly 12 hours apart.

What to look for: Stronger, more predictable rise. Should be doubling or close to it. Bubbles throughout, not just on top.

DAY 9

Timing Matters

What to do: Same feeding schedule. Start timing how long it takes to peak (reach highest rise). Write it down! This timing will be crucial for baking.

What to look for: Peak rise happening within 4-8 hours of feeding. The rise and fall cycle becomes more predictable.

Elena's Tip

Use your rubber band to track the peak. Move it up when the starter reaches maximum height. Note the time. This is your personal starter rhythm.

DAY 10

The Aroma Evolves

What to do: Continue twice daily feeds. Pay attention to how the smell changes throughout the rise cycle.

What to look for: At peak: pleasantly tangy, slightly sweet, yeasty. After peak (falling): more sour, stronger. Right after feeding: mild, floury.

DAY 11

Almost There

What to do: Keep feeding. Your starter should be consistently doubling now. If not, be patient — some starters take up to 21 days.

What to look for: Reliable doubling in 4-8 hours. Mousse-like texture when stirred. Consistent timing from feed to peak.

DAY 12

Test Run

What to do: After feeding, place a small dot of starter in a glass of room temperature water. This is the float test — but remember, it's just ONE indicator, not the only one.

What to look for: If it floats: great! Combined with the other signs, your starter is likely ready. If it sinks: don't panic. Keep feeding. The float test isn't always reliable.

Elena's Tip

The float test alone is NOT reliable. Some excellent starters don't float. Look at ALL the signs together: rise, timing, bubbles, smell, and texture.

DAY 13

Fine Tuning

What to do: Feed and observe. By now you should know your starter's personality: how fast it rises, when it peaks, how it smells at different stages.

What to look for: A mature, predictable pattern. You can almost set your clock by it.

DAY 14

Ready to Bake!

What to do: Congratulations! Feed your starter and when it reaches peak activity (4-8 hours later), you're ready to mix your first dough.

What to look for: A bubbly, active, sweet-smelling starter that reliably doubles in 4-8 hours. You did it!

Elena's Tip

Your starter is now a living part of your kitchen. With regular feeding, it will only get better with age. Some starters are passed down for generations!

Is Your Starter Ready?

The 5-Signal Readiness Check

Forget the float test as your only indicator. After years of baking, I've learned that a truly ready starter shows ALL of these signs together:

1. PREDICTABLE RISE

Doubles (or more) in size within 4-8 hours after feeding. You can predict when it will peak.

2. BUBBLES THROUGHOUT

Visible bubbles not just on the surface, but throughout the entire jar. The texture looks like mousse or sponge.

3. PLEASANT AROMA

Smells tangy and yeasty at peak — like yogurt or mild beer. Not aggressive, not like nail polish remover.

4. CONSISTENT TIMING

The time from feeding to peak is predictable, within an hour or so. You know your starter's rhythm.

5. DOME & DROP

Rises to a domed peak, holds briefly, then begins to fall. The dome shape at peak indicates strong fermentation activity.

Elena's Tip

All 5 signals together = your starter is ready to bake! 3-4 signals = almost there, keep feeding daily for a few more days. 1-2 signals = patience, you're on the right track but need more time.

Your First Loaf

The Beginner-Friendly Recipe

This is the recipe that started it all for me. Simple, forgiving, and produces a beautiful loaf every time. Perfect for your very first bake.

INGREDIENTS
400g bread flour (or strong white flour)
275g water (room temperature)
100g active starter (at peak!)
9g fine sea salt

The Timeline

MORNING (9 AM)	Mix all ingredients in a large bowl. Stir until no dry flour remains. Cover and rest for 30 minutes (autolyse).
LATE MORNING (9:30-11 AM)	Perform 3-4 sets of stretch and folds, 30 minutes apart. Wet your hands first! Stretch one side up and fold it over. Rotate bowl. Repeat on all 4 sides.
AFTERNOON (11 AM - 4 PM)	Bulk fermentation. Leave covered in a warm spot. The dough should increase 50-75% in volume, feel jiggly and airy, and show bubbles on the surface and sides.
EVENING (4-5 PM)	Shape into a round on a lightly floured surface. Let it rest 20 minutes. Shape again tightly. Place seam-side up in a floured banneton or a bowl lined with a floured tea towel.
NIGHT (5 PM)	Cover and place in the refrigerator for 12-18 hours. This cold proof develops flavor and makes scoring easier.

NEXT MORNING

Preheat oven with Dutch oven inside to 260°C / 500°F for at least 45 minutes. Score the cold dough with a sharp blade. Bake: 25 min lid ON, then 20-25 min lid OFF at 230°C / 450°F.

THE HARDEST PART

Let the bread cool for at least 1 HOUR before cutting. The inside is still cooking! Cutting too early = gummy crumb.

Troubleshooting Cheat Sheet

Everything that can go wrong, and exactly how to fix it. Save this page — you'll come back to it!

Problem	Solution
Starter won't rise	Use whole wheat flour, keep in warmer spot (24-26°C), feed consistently every 12 hours, give it more time (up to 21 days)
Dark liquid on top (hooch)	Just hungry! Pour off or stir in, then feed immediately. Consider feeding more frequently
Strong bad smell	Normal in days 3-5. If persistent after day 7: discard more (keep only 20%), feed with fresh flour. The good bacteria will win
Pink/orange streaks	Discard everything. Start over with a clean jar and fresh flour. This indicates harmful bacteria
Mold (fuzzy spots)	Discard and start fresh. Ensure your jar and utensils are clean. Don't seal the jar airtight
Flat bread	Starter wasn't at peak when mixed. Time the rise! Use starter 4-8 hours after feeding, at maximum height
Dense crumb	Under-fermented. Let bulk rise longer, do more stretch and folds, or increase kitchen temperature
Too sour	Reduce cold proof time. Use starter earlier (before peak). Feed with a higher ratio (1:3:3 instead of 1:1:1)
Sticky dough	Wet your hands. Reduce water by 10-15g next time. Use higher protein bread flour. Be gentle during shaping

Keeping Your Starter Happy

Daily Baker

If you bake 3+ times a week, keep your starter on the counter. Feed twice daily (every 12 hours): discard half, add 50g flour + 50g water. Use at peak for the best results.

Weekend Baker

If you bake once a week, keep your starter in the fridge. Take it out Friday evening, feed it. Feed again Saturday morning. By Saturday afternoon/evening, it should be at peak and ready to bake. After mixing your dough, feed the starter again and put it back in the fridge.

Going on Vacation

Feed your starter, then refrigerate immediately. A well-fed starter can survive 2-3 weeks in the fridge without feeding. When you're back, discard most of it, feed, and give it 2-3 days of regular feeding to wake up. It's more resilient than you think!

Pro Tip

Dry some starter on parchment paper as "insurance." Spread it thin, let it dry completely (24-48 hours), then crumble into a jar. Stored in a cool, dry place, dried starter can last for months or even years. To revive: add equal parts flour and water and feed daily.

Want to make tracking your starter effortless?

Rise & Ferment is a free app that helps you track feedings, monitor your starter's health, and know exactly when it's ready to bake. Built by a sourdough nerd (that's me) for people who love good bread but don't want to memorize schedules.

riseandferment.com

Track multiple starters. Get feeding reminders. See your progress. Available in 6 languages. Completely free.

Thank you for downloading this guide.

Now go make something beautiful. Your kitchen is waiting.

Share this guide with anyone who wants to start their sourdough journey.

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